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DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS

Veterans Benefits Administration
Regional Office — Waco, Texas

James R. Calloway
1420 Bluebonnet Lane
Temple, TX 76502

In Reply Refer To:
VA File Number: **999-88-7777**
Decision Date: **October 6, 2026**

Dear Mr. Calloway:

INTRODUCTION

The records reflect that you are a veteran of the Gulf War Era. You served in the United States Army from June 12, 1998 to June 11, 2004. A claim for an increased evaluation for posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD), service connection for a lumbosacral strain, a right knee condition, and migraine headaches, and continuation of the current evaluations for tinnitus, bilateral hearing loss, and a left knee condition was received on March 14, 2025. This rating decision addresses each issue below.

In making this decision, VA considered your service treatment records, your post-service VA treatment records from the Central Texas Veterans Health Care System for the period January 2023 through August 2026, and the Compensation and Pension examination reports dated June 2025 and July 2025.

DECISION

The following evaluations are assigned based on the evidence of record:

Disability	Diagnostic Code	Evaluation	Effective Date	Decision
Posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD)	9411	70%	03/14/2025	Increased
Lumbosacral strain	5237	20%	03/14/2025	Service connection granted
Tinnitus	6260	10%	03/14/2025	Continued
Left knee limitation of flexion	5260	0%	03/14/2025	Continued
Right knee instability	5257	--	--	Service connection denied
Migraine headaches	8100	--	--	Deferred

Your combined evaluation is **80 percent**, effective March 14, 2025. Combined evaluations are determined under 38 CFR 4.25 and are not arrived at by adding the individual evaluations together.

REASONS FOR DECISION

1. Evaluation of posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD). An increased evaluation of 70 percent is assigned under Diagnostic Code 9411 effective March 14, 2025. The June 2025 examination shows occupational and social impairment with deficiencies in most areas, including suicidal ideation,

near-continuous panic affecting the ability to function independently, and difficulty adapting to stressful circumstances. A higher evaluation of 100 percent is not warranted because the evidence does not show total occupational and social impairment.

2. Service connection for lumbosacral strain. Service connection is granted under Diagnostic Code 5237, and an evaluation of 20 percent is assigned effective March 14, 2025. Your service treatment records show treatment for low back pain following a lifting injury in 2002, and the July 2025 examiner provided a medical opinion linking your current lumbosacral strain to that in-service injury.

3. Evaluation of tinnitus. The 10 percent evaluation for tinnitus under Diagnostic Code 6260 is continued. Ten percent is the maximum evaluation authorized under this diagnostic code, and the evidence does not show a basis for an extraschedular referral.

4. Evaluation of left knee limitation of flexion. The noncompensable (0 percent) evaluation under Diagnostic Code 5260 is continued. Flexion was measured at 135 degrees at the June 2025 examination, which does not meet the criteria for a compensable evaluation.

5. Service connection for right knee instability. Service connection is **denied**. While you have a current diagnosis of mild right knee instability, the evidence does not show an injury or disease in service, nor a link between your current condition and your military service. The examiner's opinion of July 2025 concluded the condition is less likely than not related to service.

6. Service connection for migraine headaches. This issue is **deferred**. A medical opinion has been requested to determine whether your migraine headaches are related to service or secondary to your service-connected tinnitus. A supplemental decision will be issued when that development is complete.

WHAT YOU SHOULD DO IF YOU DISAGREE WITH THIS DECISION

If you disagree with this decision, you have **one year from the date of this letter (October 6, 2026)** to select a review option in order to preserve the earliest possible effective date for any benefits payable on a continuously pursued claim. Your options are:

• **Supplemental Claim** (VA Form 20-0995) — file if you have new and relevant evidence VA has not previously considered.

• **Higher-Level Review** (VA Form 20-0996) — request a review by a more experienced reviewer based on the evidence already in the record; no new evidence may be submitted.

• **Board Appeal** (VA Form 10182, Decision Review Request: Board Appeal / Notice of Disagreement) — appeal directly to the Board of Veterans' Appeals and choose the Direct Review, Evidence Submission, or Hearing docket.

If you do not select a review option within one year — by **October 6, 2027** — this decision becomes final, and any later claim will generally be assigned a later effective date.

Sincerely,

Regional Office Rating Activity
Veterans Benefits Administration

This is a fictional sample letter generated for software testing. James R. Calloway is not a real person and VA File Number 999-88-7777 is not a real file number.

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